Question #1

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Have You Done Market Validation (Interviews) Before?

- ❑ Yes, lots of them!
- ❑ Yes, some.
- ❑ No, but I think that I know how to do this!
- ❑ No, not really sure how to go about it.
- ❑ Huh?

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Data Vs. Assumptions



Via: https://leanstartup.co/talking-to-humans-success-starts-with-understanding-your-customers/

- Have you identified a need?
- Is it a *clear* need?
- Is it a *"big enough"* problem?
- "Tackling problems that are interesting to solve rather than those that serve a market need was cited as the No. 1 reason for [startup] failure, noted in 42 percent of cases."

CBI Insights – "The Top 20 Reasons Startups Fail"

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The Challenge



- 56 Years of Education
- 2 PhDs/1 Masters
- 13 Years of Research
- 2 Filed Patents/1 Pending
- ~0 Market Insight

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Beginning Market Discovery

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“I-Lean”



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Some Lean Techniques?

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- **Discovery Interviews** - “Conversations”
  - **Desktop Research** – background (1st questions smarter)
- **MVP –** Minimum Viable Product
- Curated Experience – “Pre-automated” “Product”
- Other – surveys (consumer), conferences, etc.

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Best Validation = “Conversations”

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Two Big Challenges

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Interview Challenges

- Are we asking the Right Questions?
- Are we talking to the Right People?
  - Identifying them
  - Reaching them

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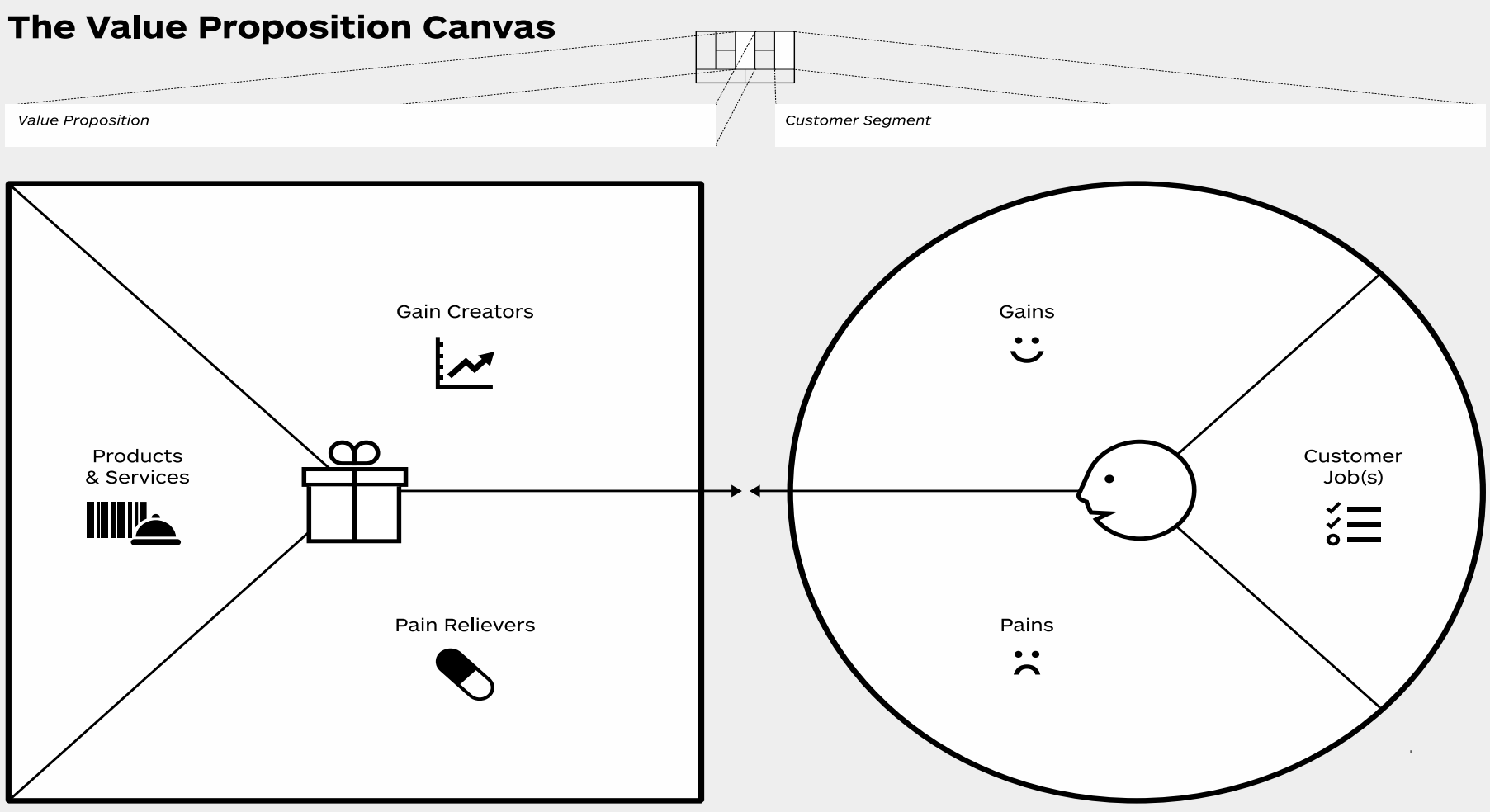
Empathy –
Cognitive
Emotional
Compassionate

"See the world from the perspective of Another".

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The Customer's Reality

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What is the customer PROBLEM/Need?

How do *they* "frame" the problem?

How have they tried to address problem?

What would the "ideal" solution look like?

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Basic Discovery

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- **WHO** *IS* your "customer"? (who will buy?)
- WHAT *IS* the "job to be done"? (real one)
- WHAT are the "pains" you can alleviate?
  - Reduce costs?
  - Increase revenues/profits?
  - Stay out of trouble?
- WHAT are the "gains" you can provide?
- WHAT is the "product" you should offer?

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Start With Assumptions

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- "This consumer or companies (exact role) will buy our product"
- "This is the job they're doing/trying to do"
- "This is the problem (pain) that they have and how our offering will address it"
- "These are the gains we believe that they will also get"

If you don't have assumptions – do some online research, talk with your CC (others) and come up with them.

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Assumptions – Good News

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“Each time our assumptions are proven wrong, we evolve.”

- K S Ramanan

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Question #2 - Surveys

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Why can't I use surveys instead of interviews?

A Surveys are expensive!

B People won't respond to surveys without a prize!

C I don't know the right questions for a survey.

D I'm not sure who to survey.

E A & B

F C & D

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Question #2

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F C & D

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Surveys

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- There are low- and no-cost tools to do surveys online

BUT

- Difficult to get people to respond to surveys
- Need to be carefully designed and targeted . . . You MUST know the right questions!
- Surveys good for *quantification* – i.e. "how common is this response?"
- We did a survey of consumers w/ MusigPro in GRIP 2 to find interest from people in assessing their singing
- In other words – surveys may be a good "follow-on"

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Interviews – How to Ask Questions

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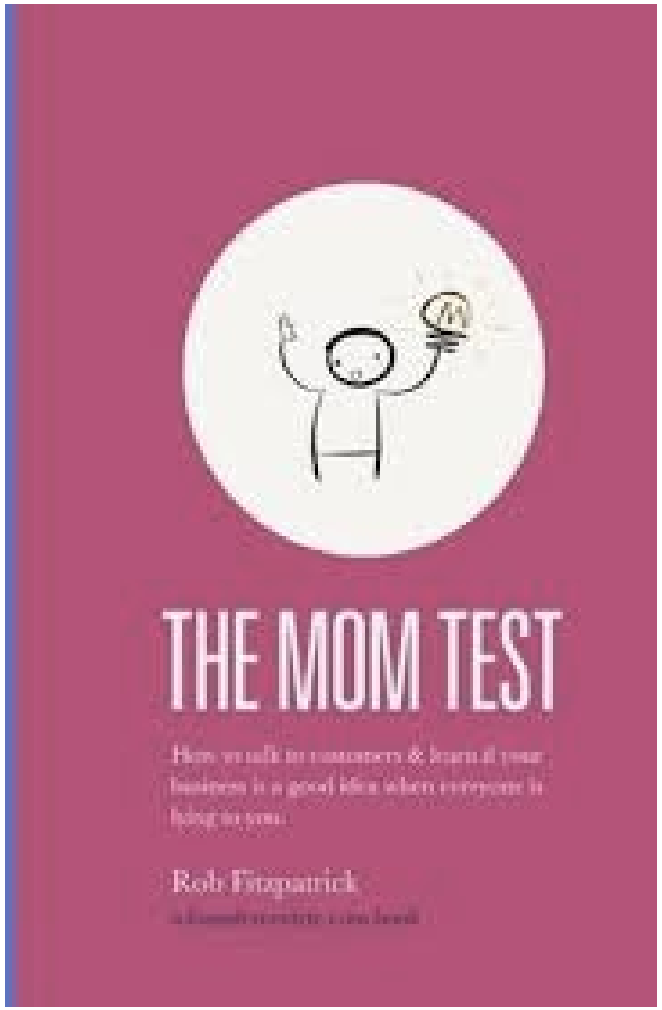
Formulating Questions

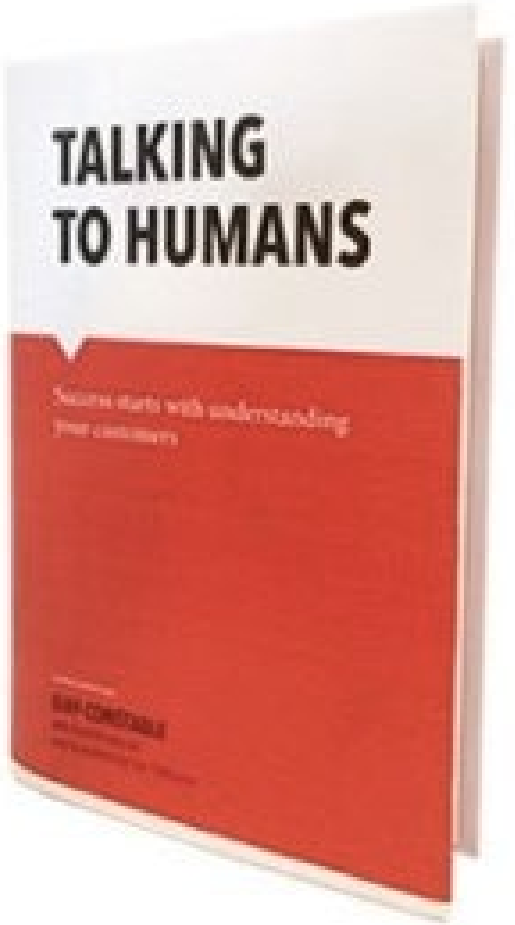
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- Question most basic/essential assumptions first.
- You don't have to question common sense.
- Open ended questions (don't "lead")
  - "Please, tell me how you . . . "
  - "Can you share something about . . . ?"
  - "What are the most important . . . ?"
- DON'T SELL!!!

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Two Books To Read





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The “Mom Test”

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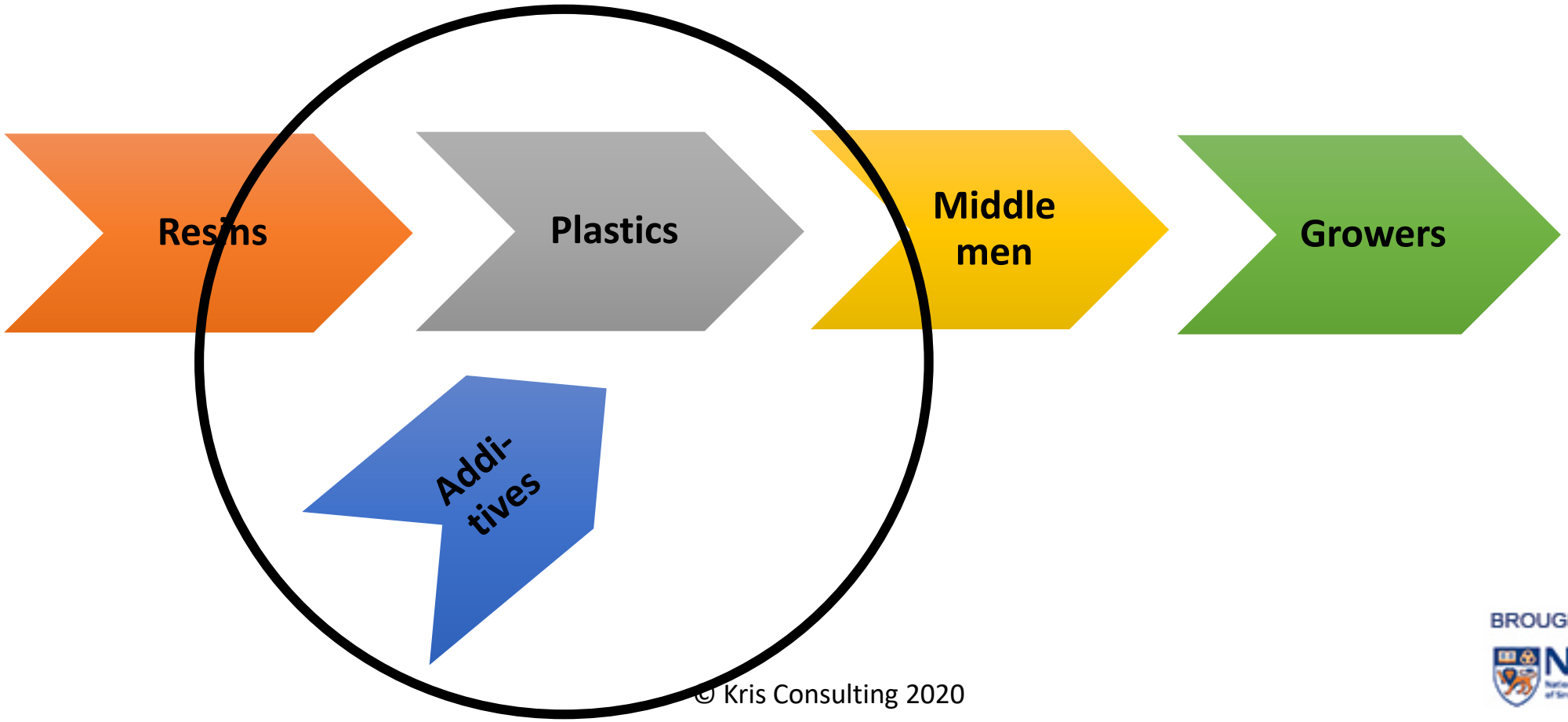
“1. Talk about their life instead of your idea [technology]

2. Ask about specifics in the past instead of generics or opinions about the future

3. Talk less and listen more”

- What are your “3 Big Questions”?

Your Supply Chain



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The “Right” People

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- Are you interviewing those who have a clear and strong need/application for your solution?
  - Save them money?
  - Make them money?
  - Improve their work in some way?
- If they’re not the “right” people – can they point you to the “right” people?

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How To Ask Questions ("Converse")

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- Be friendly & establish rapport
- OPEN QUESTIONS
- SIMPLE ?S
- Be "Concrete"
- DON'T SELL
- NOT a lecture
- 2nd (note taker)



- Don't interrupt
- Don't "lead"
- Don't argue
- *Anything else I should have asked?*
- Immediate write-up
- Close with request for referrals

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The “Mom Test”

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“1. Talk about their life instead of your idea [technology]

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- What are your “3 Big Questions”?

Exercise: Build a Better Wallet

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1. We will split into meeting rooms for 11 minutes – 2 randomly per room
2. You have 1 minute to introduce yourselves
3. You each have 5 minutes to ask each other 1 or 2 questions of the other about what kind of wallet they might need.
4. When we come back together after 11 minutes, you will 3 minutes to write up the answers and a creative wallet you might design.

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Exercise: Build a Better Wallet

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Possible Questions:

- When do you use a wallet? (If you don't, why not?)
- How many times do you use your wallet each day?
- What is something that your wallet *can't do* that you would like it to do?

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Examples of Answer -> Product

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When do you use a wallet? (If you don't, why not?)

- "I generally carry a little money 'loose'"
- "Mostly I need a wallet for a few critical cards"
- "I use my phone for almost everything else"

Anything troublesome about the current wallet?

- "One more thing to carry!"



Via: https://www.businessinsider.com/phone-wallet-case-card-holders-2018-10#lameeku-wallet-case-5

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A Few Pointers

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- Don’t converge too quickly – either during interviews OR in testing your assumptions
- ***Don’t*** get overwhelmed by one powerful interview
- Accept the tension of not having a clear answer immediately
- Look for insights – sometimes surprising ones

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Video Calls

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- Be sure that you aren't using video conferencing that won't lead to your being "kicked off" prematurely! (i.e. free zoom)

  that your video background works if you use it green screen if necessary

- Make sure that lighting and sound are good from your end

: Telegenic – Episodes



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: Telegenic – Episodes



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Finding interviewees

Realities

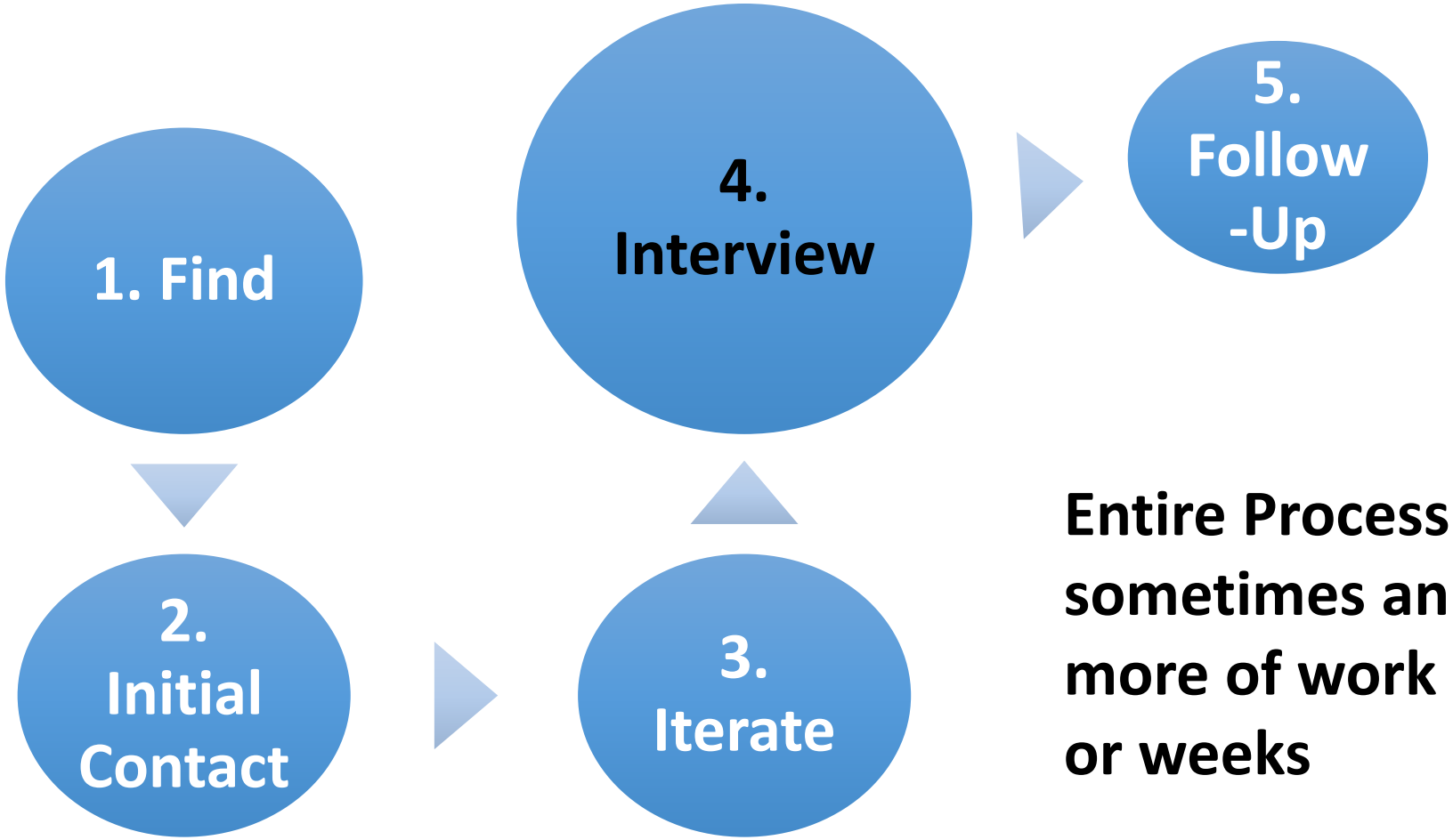
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- People are busy/being interviewed is (usually) **not** their job
- You want to talk to people with deep knowledge (often busiest)
- *Getting* interviews can be a challenge. Allow time and focus to get it right.

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Interview Cycle



Entire Process – sometimes an hour or more of work over days or weeks

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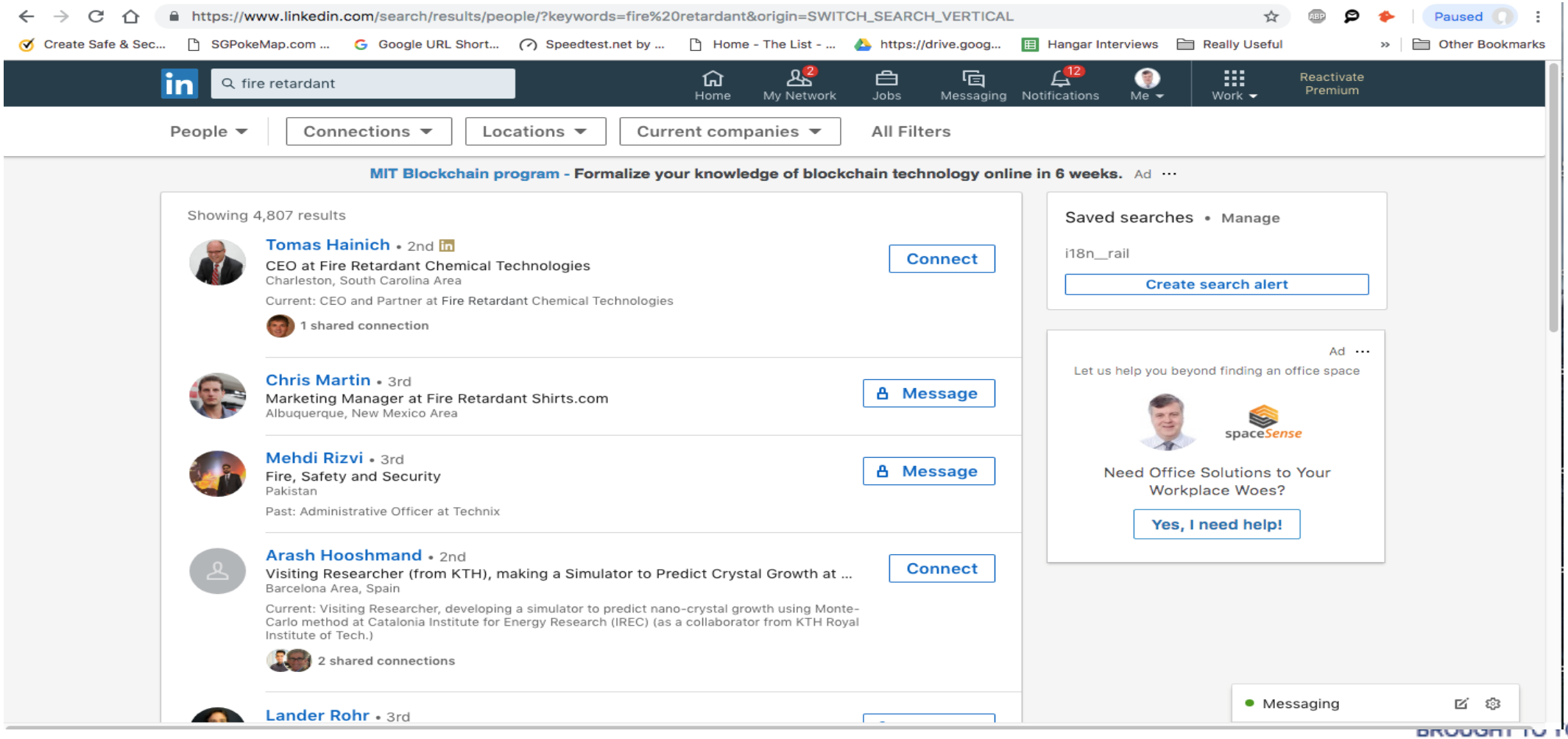
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Question #3

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- ❑ I have an “simple” LinkedIN account
- ❑ I have a filled up LinkedIN account (photo, my background, etc)
- ❑ I don’t have a LinkedIN account

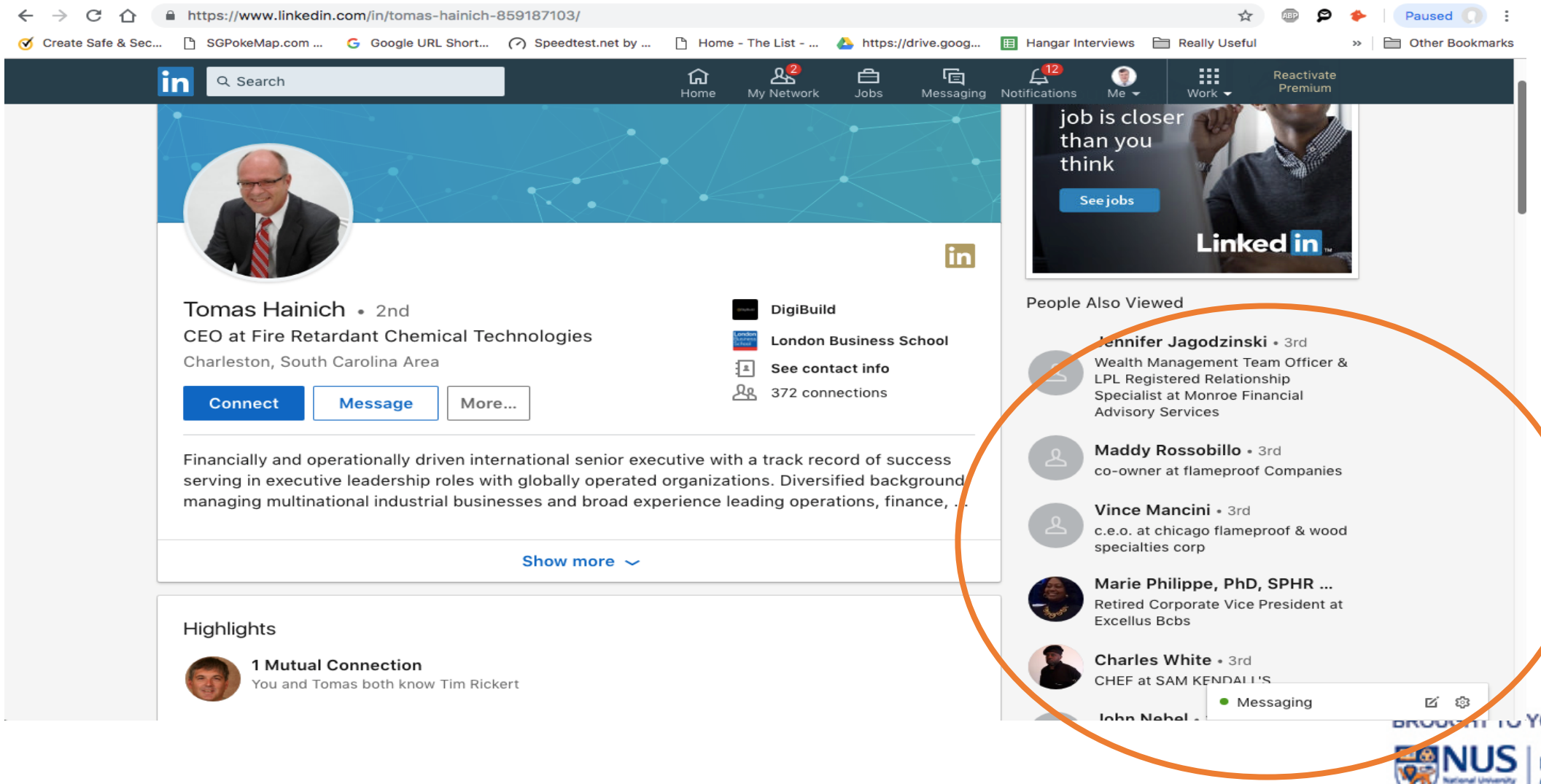
LinkedIN Search



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LinkedIN Search



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Best Way To Contact

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- E-MAIL – usually the best way to reach out unless you can contact via an in-line system.

  fact ☹: Most networks (LI, FB) won't send your sages (unless you're direct connect or pay extra for "in-line" messages).

- Phone calls can work (if you can get phone #) but requires skill.

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Find E-Mail Addresses

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- Using LinkedIN or other sources of names/companies - there are now some tools:
  - ContactOut.com – free trial
  - Hunter.io – must use “off-line” from LinkedIN
  - Zoominfo- free trial
  - Look for others and share with us
- Google – if they have spoken at an event, or if there is a profile – e-mails *sometimes* included
- Find e-mail “format” for company (i.e.,) and “take a shot”.

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Finding the "Boss"

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- LinkedIN (sometimes)
- Annual Reports/Company website
  - Look for organization's "leaders"
- Others: Hoovers, Bloomberg, S&P and other (sometimes paid) services

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Reach Out To Their Boss

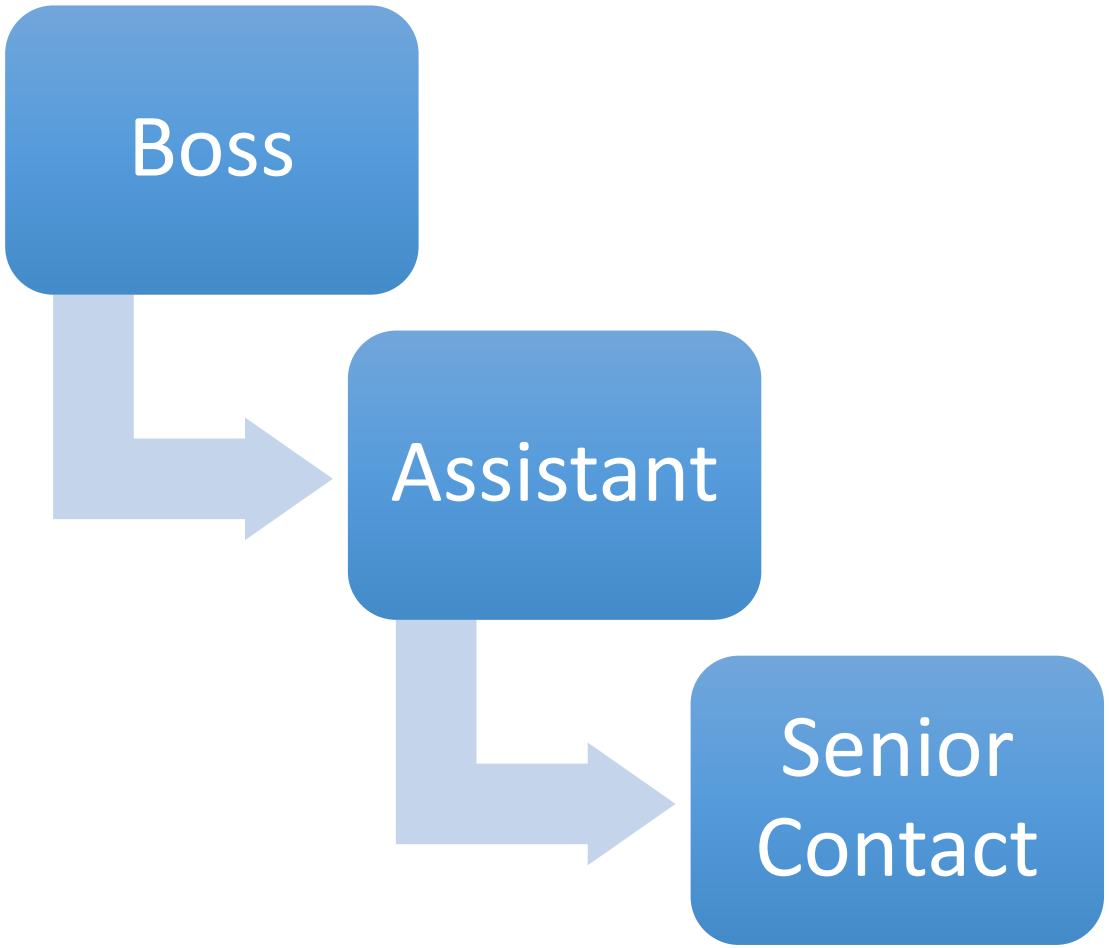
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- The key people you want to reach may be "buried" in organizations – busy, hard to find/hard to reach
- Don't go too "high" in large organizations (probably **not** top CEO, Chairman, etc.)
- "*I may not answer your e-mail – but I will if my boss (or his/her boss) asks me*"
  - Go to the company's annual report
  - Locate the probable CEO/President/Director (whose job is to look ahead/outside for the targeted business)
  - Send him/her an e-mail and ask for introduction

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Possible Contact Flow



- **May go another level or 2**

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Final Prep Before Interview

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Find out what you reasonably can about the person you will be interviewing. For example:

- How long have they been in this job?
- What did they do previously? (deep domain knowledge or new to the space?)
- Education?
- Where are they from?
- What is their organization doing in the “space”?

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Follow Up

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Follow Up

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- End interview asking:
  - If it is OK to contact interviewee again if new questions arise.
  - For referrals (ideally, they can introduce you – ask!)
- ***Promptly send a brief, personalized follow-up e-mail of thanks***

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A Word of ENCOURAGEMENT

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- Validation – understanding the market into which you will sell your product – can be challenging.
- Prepare/Get Help/Be Persistent
- Be Flexible
- Don’t be discouraged by “negative” responses (wrong application? Wrong person? Wrong question?)
- Hundreds of NUS teams have done this before.

The end – Questions?

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